paid in yellow

PACK 1 · THE PAYCHECK PAYOFF SYSTEM

The 7-Day Debt Reset

Seven small steps, about 15 minutes a day. At the end you have a plan for every payday and a buffer between you and the next surprise bill.

1	2	3	4	5	6	7

Color a box each day you finish.

one paycheck at a time

BEFORE YOU START

How this works

One page a day. The PaidInYellow app does the math. You do one small thing and color a box.

You need

1. Your card and loan statements, or your banking app.
2. The PaidInYellow app open on your phone.
3. A pen and a yellow highlighter.

Three rules

1. Do today's page only. Tomorrow can wait.
2. Missed a day? Do it tomorrow. Life happens. Never miss twice.
3. Rough numbers are fine. You can fix them later.

What changes in 7 days

Today you may not know when this ends. In a week you will know your debt-free date, what to pay on your next payday, where your surprise money lives, and you will have made your first planned payment.

A note on money words

We write **$** in this workbook. Read it as your own currency. **Minimum** is the smallest payment your statement asks for. **Rate** is the interest rate, shown as APR on your statement. **Buffer** is money set aside for surprises.

Your seven boxes

Each day page ends with a box. Color it when you finish. Seven yellow boxes is a finished Reset.



You're not bad at math. The math was hidden from you.

YOUR WEEK

Seven days at a glance

DAY	WHAT YOU DO	TIME	DONE
1	See everything you owe, and your debt-free date	20 min	☐
2	Find your first $500	15 min	☐
3	Give your buffer a home	15 min	☐
4	Meet your plan	10 min	☐
5	Set your 10-minute payday ritual	10 min	☐
6	List the bills that aren't really surprises	15 min	☐
7	Make your first planned payment and color your first box	10 min	☐

I start on

Date _____ My next payday _____

Why I'm doing this

One sentence. Who or what is it for?

_____

_____

_____

What I'm worried about

Write it down so it stops spinning in your head. You'll look at it again on Day 7.

DAY 1 OF 7 · ABOUT 20 MINUTES

Day 1

See everything

Today you only look. No fixing yet. Most people never write it all down in one place, and that's why it feels endless.

1. Open every statement or banking app: cards, store cards, loans, buy now pay later, medical bills, money from family.
2. Write each one below. The rate and minimum are on the statement.
3. Type them into the app. It takes 4 short steps and shows your debt-free date.

NAME	BALANCE	RATE %	MINIMUM	DUE DAY

My debt-free date, from the app

Highlight it in yellow.

How I feel, in one word

☐ **Day 1 done.** Color the box.

Looking is the bravest step. You just took it.

DAY 2 OF 7 · ABOUT 15 MINUTES

Day 2

Find your first $500

More than 1 in 3 adults couldn't cover a $400 surprise with cash. Your first $500 is what keeps the next surprise off your cards. It goes to your buffer first.

1. Read the 30 ideas on the next page. Tick the ones that fit your life.
2. Pick your best 5 and write what each could bring in.
3. Do one of them today, even a small one.

MY IDEA	ABOUT HOW MUCH	DONE
	$	☐
	$	☐
	$	☐
	$	☐
	$	☐

If I do all five

Add them up. It's often closer to $500 than people expect.

$

In the app: Safety net, then **Find your first $500**. Tick what you do and the total adds itself up.

☐ **Day 2 done.** Color the box.

Small money is still money.

DAY 2 · THE LIST

30 ways to find money

Tick what fits. No loans, no new cards, nothing that costs you later.

SPEND LESS

- [ ] Pause 2 subscriptions for a month
- [ ] Cancel one streaming service
- [ ] Call your phone company for a cheaper plan
- [ ] Ask your internet provider for a better price
- [ ] Compare car or home insurance quotes
- [ ] Eat from the pantry and freezer for a week
- [ ] Skip takeout for two weeks
- [ ] Make coffee at home this month
- [ ] Shop with a list and stick to it
- [ ] Switch to store brands for a month
- [ ] Delete saved cards from shopping sites and apps
- [ ] Unsubscribe from store emails

SELL OR RETURN

- [ ] Sell 3 things you don't use
- [ ] Sell clothes you haven't worn in a year
- [ ] Sell old phones, tablets or consoles
- [ ] Sell kids' gear they've outgrown
- [ ] Sell furniture or tools you don't need
- [ ] Return something you haven't used
- [ ] Sell gift cards you won't use

EARN A LITTLE MORE

- [ ] Pick up extra hours or a shift
- [ ] Babysit or pet sit for neighbors
- [ ] Yard work, moving help or snow shoveling
- [ ] Deliver or drive on weekends
- [ ] Sell a skill: tutoring, repairs, hair, cleaning
- [ ] Ask about overtime or a better-paid shift

MONEY ALREADY YOURS

- [ ] Use gift cards you forgot about
- [ ] Search your name at missingmoney.com (US unclaimed money)
- [ ] Claim refunds for late or broken orders
- [ ] Send cash back and rebates straight to your buffer
- [ ] Put any surprise money, like a tax refund, on the plan

Give your buffer a home

The buffer is money for surprises, so a car repair or a doctor's bill doesn't go back on a card. It's the step most plans skip, and the one that keeps you out of debt.

1. Choose a home for it: a plain separate account at your bank or credit union, or an envelope at home.
2. Name it so you know what it's for: **Surprises** or **Buffer**.
3. Put in what you can today, even $10.
4. Type the amount in the app, on Safety net.

My buffer lives _____

Today I put in $ _____ My goal $ _____

Color $50 at a time

50	100	150	200	250	300	350	400	450	500

Keep it boring

1. No card linked to it, so it's not easy to spend.
2. Use it only for real surprises: repairs, medical, an urgent trip.
3. Used some? That's what it's for. Tap **I used some of it** and your plan refills it first.

☐ **Day 3 done.** Color the box.

A buffer turns a crisis into an errand.

Meet your plan

The app pays your smallest debt first, unless one grows even with its minimum. A study of about 6,000 people in a debt program found that clearing small balances first made people more likely to finish.

1. Open **Path**. Find your debt-free date and the first debt to go.
2. Tap **What if I add more?** Add $20 each payday and watch the date move.
3. Leave the slider where it feels honest. Tap **Use this in my plan** only if you can keep it up.

My first debt to go _____ gone by _____

With $20 more each payday, my date becomes _____

My debts, in the order the app pays them _____

_____

Why one debt at a time

Every debt gets its minimum. All the extra goes to one debt until it's gone. Then its minimum joins the extra for the next one. The amount you pay each payday stays the same, but it clears debts faster and faster.

My why, in a picture

Draw it, write it or stick a photo here. Look at it on payday.

☐ **Day 4 done.** Color the box.

You can see the end now.

DAY 5 OF 7 · ABOUT 10 MINUTES

Day 5

Your 10-minute payday ritual

People who decide when and where they'll act follow through far more often. So we decide now, once.

When I get paid on _____, I open PaidInYellow at _____ at _____.

day · time · place (kitchen table, car before work, lunch break)

The ritual, every payday

1. Open **Today**. It shows one amount to move.
2. Pay the bills on the list in your banking app.
3. Move the buffer and yearly bills money to their home.
4. Send the extra to the debt the app names.
5. Tap **I did it**. Watch it turn yellow. Done until next payday.

1. Fill in the sentence above.
2. In the app, add the **Payday reminder**. It goes into your phone's calendar.
3. Cut out the ritual card on page 13 and keep it in your wallet or on the fridge.

Practice run

I tried the ritual on _____ It took _____ minutes

One thing that would make it easier _____

☐ **Day 5 done.** Color the box.

Ten minutes, every payday. That's the whole job.

Day 6

Bills that aren't surprises

Some bills come every year, just not every month. When they land all at once, they go on a card. A little each payday stops that.

Ideas: car repairs · car registration · gifts and holidays · birthdays · school costs · insurance renewals · pet care · doctor and dentist · a trip home · home repairs

BILL	PER YEAR	MONTH NEEDED	IN APP
	$		☐
	$		☐
	$		☐
	$		☐
	$		☐
	$		☐
	$		☐
	$		☐

1. List every bill like this you can think of. Guess the yearly amount if you need to.
2. Add your top two or three in the app: **Safety net**, then **Add a bill**.
3. The app sets aside a small amount each payday. You don't have to work it out.

Not sure about a yearly amount?

Look back at last year in your banking app. What did you spend on it in total? Use that number.

☐ **Day 6 done.** Color the box.

Planned money is calm money.

DAY 7 OF 7 · ABOUT 10 MINUTES

Day 7

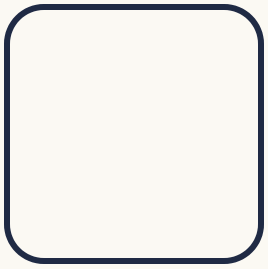
First payment, first yellow

Today you do the ritual for real. If your payday isn't today, do it on your payday and come back to color the box.

1. Follow your ritual card: open Today, pay, move, send the extra.
2. Tap **I did it** and watch it turn yellow.
3. Color the box below, and the first square on your tracker.

Date _____ Total moved $ _____

The extra went to _____



My first planned payment

Color it yellow. This is what paid looks like.

You finished the Reset

A week ago you may not have known when this would end. Now you have a date, a buffer with a home, a payday ritual and your first payment done. From here, it's ten minutes each payday. Turn back to page 3 and read what you were worried about. Does it feel the same now?

Day 7 done. Color the last box on the cover too.

One down. Keep going, one paycheck at a time.

KEEP THIS PAGE

Wobble? Reset.

A bad week, a charge on the card, a missed payday. It happens to almost everyone who gets out of debt. A wobble only becomes a fall if you stop.

1. Breathe. Don't open every statement in a panic.
2. Open the app. Put a new charge on its debt (**Debts**, then **Add a new charge or fee**), or tap **Skip this payday**.
3. Read your new date. It moved a little. It didn't disappear.
4. On your next payday, do the ritual. Never miss twice.

What happened

What I'll do on my next payday

One thing that would make it easier next time

If the plan can't work right now

If your minimums are more than the money you have, that happens, and there are people whose job is to help. Call each lender and ask about a hardship program. In the US, a nonprofit credit counselor (NFCC.org) can help you make a plan. Avoid anyone who offers a new loan to fix it.

Life happens. Never miss twice.

CUT OUT AND KEEP

Your payday ritual card

Two copies: one for your wallet, one for the fridge.

paid in yellow

Payday · 10 minutes

1. Open Today
2. Pay the bills listed
3. Move buffer and yearly bills money
4. Send the extra to the named debt
5. Tap I did it

When I get paid on _____, I open it at _____.

paid in yellow

Payday · 10 minutes

1. Open Today
2. Pay the bills listed
3. Move buffer and yearly bills money
4. Send the extra to the named debt
5. Tap I did it

When I get paid on _____, I open it at _____.

When a surprise bill lands

1. Pay it from the buffer, not a card.
2. Tap **I used some of it** on Safety net.
3. The plan refills the buffer first. Nothing else to do.

one paycheck at a time

AFTER THE RESET

What's next

Every payday

Do the 10-minute ritual. Check your date on Path once a month. When a statement arrives, use **Update from my statement** on Debts so the numbers match your real balance.

Debt-Free Tracker Kit

Print a tracker and color a square for every payday and every $100 paid. It's in your Pack 1 download.

Never Back in Debt Guide

What to do when a surprise bill lands, how to talk to your lenders, and how to stay out once you're free. Also in your download.

Save a backup

Your plan lives only on your phone. Once a month, tap **Save backup** in the app and keep the file somewhere safe, like your email or cloud drive.

Stuck on something?

Email support@paidinyellow.com. A screenshot helps. A real person answers.

PaidInYellow is a planning tool, not financial advice. Figures are estimates based on what you enter. We never suggest loans, balance transfers or new credit. The study mentioned on page 8 is Gal and McShane (2012). The $400 figure is from the Federal Reserve's 2025 survey of household economics.